

Vishal Talreja

Vishal Talreja (born ~1970s) co-founded Dream a Dream in 1999, pioneering creative life skills education for 2.2M+ vulnerable youth in India.

Education

- Bachelor's in Commerce and Accounting, Bangalore University.
- Active member of AIESEC international student organization.

Career

Started in corporate: Xerox India, startup investment bank Technology Holdings India Pvt. Ltd. Co-founded Dream a Dream (1999) with 11 others as Bangalore charitable trust; served as CEO (1999-2018), scaling from volunteer camps to 2.2M children impacted. Transitioned to The Cocoon Initiative (Co-Founder) for NGO leader sabbaticals; Board Member at Goonj, PYE Global; Founding Team at The Weaving Lab, Catalyst 2030.

Awards and Recognition

- Ashoka Fellow.
- Eisenhower Fellow.
- Salzburg Global Fellow.
- Steering Committee Member, Karanga Global Alliance on SEL/Life Skills.

Vishal Talreja's Story

In his early 20s as a corporate professional, Vishal Talreja traveled to Finland and experienced child-centric schools where learning through play fostered creativity and emotional intelligence. He was stunned by the contrast: "Success in exams doesn't equal success in life—our system crushes dreams." Returning to Bangalore slums, he witnessed children surviving extreme trauma (abuse, poverty, domestic violence) yet displaying untapped resilience when engaged through stories, games, and arts rather than rote academics. With no formal education background, he rallied 11 friends for weekend volunteer camps in the slums. A chance meeting with education mentor Ashok Khurana proved pivotal—the mentor challenged: "Don't work with middle-class kids who already have opportunities. Go to the poorest of poor." They did, running theater-based sessions where children "lit up" expressing suppressed emotions. This validated creative life skills > traditional teaching. Vishal quit his high-paying startup banking job, bootstrapped Dream a Dream from ₹50k personal savings, and built India's SEL pioneer—now mainstreaming "thriving" nationally through govt partnerships.



Leadership at Dream a Dream

Under his vision, the organization has grown into a registered charitable trust empowering children and young people from vulnerable backgrounds to overcome adversity and flourish in the 21st century using a creative life skills approach. Today, Dream a Dream works with 10,000 young people a year through two innovation labs — the After School Life Skills Programme and the Career Connect Programme — and has trained over 35,000 teachers and educators, impacting more than 875,000 children and young people, with a reach extending to over 3 million children through state government partnerships in Delhi, Jharkhand, Uttarakhand, Telangana, Nagaland, and Karnataka.

Vishal's experience as a thought leader has enabled him to transform the ecosystem by empowering key stakeholders in education — including teachers, school leaders, and policymakers — to shape education vision and strategy, and to influence global networks of changemakers. He has co-authored four research papers on life skills in the Indian context, contributed to white papers and policy briefs on education transformation, and co-authored the book *When We Thrive, Our World Thrives*. Recognized as an "Architect of the Future" by the Waldzell Institut in Austria and as "Innovator of the Year" in 2019 by HundrED, he also received The Better India's "Education Changemaker of the Year" award in 2025 for his 25-year work through Dream a Dream.